

Off the Shelf



Rise of Nations

All rise! Here comes the emperor!

Rise of Nations, the latest contender in the race of RTS (Real Time Strategy) games, is much more logical, mature, and satisfying, as compared to previous titles.

It features eight ages, based on the human race's development checkpoints. Advance from one age to the next, based on research done in certain fields. Choose from a cartful of civilisations. Each nation has been painstakingly given a unique appearance in terms of uniforms, buildings, units etc.

The game supports up to eight nations on the map. A scenario editor is included to make your own maps. Take over nations through War, Diplomacy, Espionage, etc. Guard your borders till you advance



GETTING CIVILISED: Develop a state-of-the-art city, complete with modern buildings and famous 'wonders'

enough to build up a strong army, or plan a surprise attack on the opponent. You can team up with a nation to combine and attack a third nation.

The game has a remarkable artificial intelligence level. For example, if left idle, citizens automatically try to find work for themselves, be it raising crop, or repairing buildings. They automatically return to their previous work after doing the job you called on them for.

Static objects such as buildings, and moving units that allow for inter unit interaction, are rendered in intricate 2D graphics to allow for greater details. Hence, this provides a high level of detail and realism, for which a high end graphics card is a must.

Indeed, it is a well-planned RTS game and offers numerous ways to take the game forward. All in all, this game is worth a try.

Genre: Strategy ■ **Developer:** Big Huge Games ■ **Publisher:** Microsoft Game Studios ■ **System Requirements:** Windows: XP/2000/ME/98, 128 MB RAM, 500 MHz CPU, 800 MB disk space, 16 MB 3D card ■ **Online/multiplayer requirements:** 56.6 Kbps or better for Internet play
Rating: ★★★★★

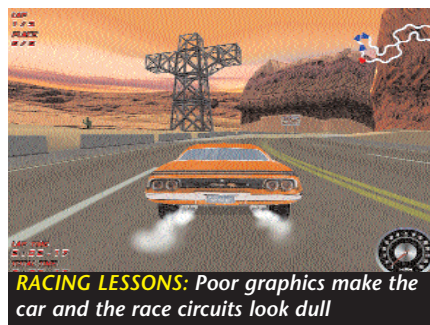


Muscle Car 2: American Spirit

Racing for the absolute beginner

Muscle Car 2: American Spirit is a racing game that's based on 1970s muscle cars, which were immensely popular in the US for their brute power and looks. The game has a weird interface that made browsing the menu a tough task. We were surprised to find that there was no option to change the controller settings. The game has four modes of play: Time Trial, Rally, Bandit and Career. You can select a car and the character accompanied to race in any of the four modes.

In the Time Trial mode, you have to race against the clock and cross various check points in a certain amount of time. In the Rally mode, the racer has to com-



RACING LESSONS: Poor graphics make the car and the race circuits look dull

pete against opponents in race circuits, and place first, second or third to clear a track. In the Bandit mode you race against one opponent on street circuits—be ready to

handle cops who don't like the idea of street racing at all. Then there is the career mode where you can earn money by winning races. With this money you can buy better cars, upgrades, etc.

All the car models looked much the same, differing only in textures. It also has poor game physics and artificial intelligence. The opponents were bumping into each other for no apparent reason. The overall graphics quality was also disappointing. The tracks looked uninteresting as the scenes seemed to be repeating and we also found the tracks to be too long. This is not a game for die hard racers, but its low price tag makes it worth a try.

Genre: Arcade Racing ■ **Developer:** 3 Romans LLC ■ **Publisher:** Global Star Software ■ **Contact:** Sujata Infotech ■ **System requirements:** 500 MHz CPU, 64 MB RAM, 4X CD-ROM, 150 MB disk space, 8 MB 3D graphics card ■ **Price:** Rs 199 ■ **Phone:** 022-22846574/22885096
Fax: 022-22840234 ■ **E-mail:** sales@sujata.net ■ **Web site:** www.globalstarsoftware.com
Rating: ★★☆☆☆